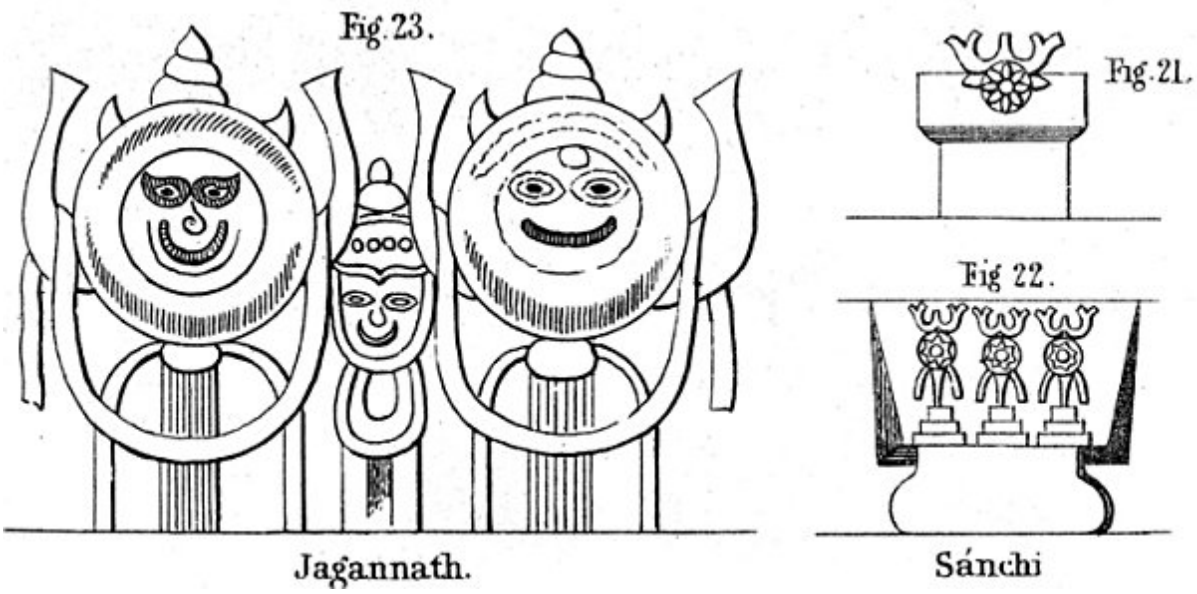


The three *darus* worshipped at the Jagannath temple at Puri (left) compared to the Buddhist *triratna* (‘three jewels’) symbols carved on the pillars of the Great Stupa at Sanchi (right).

So far, so much wishful thinking, but Cunningham was on firmer ground when he drew attention to the *ratha yatra* procession at Puri, which he regarded has having its origins in the Buddhist custom of annually parading Buddha relics in a *ratha*. There was also the fact that all the caste prohibitions which were then in force in Cunningham’s time were lifted during the festival, which he saw as a sop to the previously Buddhist lower castes. Finally, there was what Cunningham called ‘the belief that the image [the Jagannath *daru*] contains the relics or bones of Krishna’. All these facts, led Cunningham to conclude that the Jagannath deity and its *ratha yatra* were a continuation of a Buddhist rite that had originally involved the Buddha’s tooth being carried in procession round the Buddhist temple built to house it.

Cunningham, it must be said, had something of an obsession about Greek influences and Buddhist origins. Even so, his theory that the Jagannath temple had its origins in the tooth relic of the Buddha was supported by other